

Session 8: God's Second Promise to Abram

Key Takeaways

- God's promise to make Avram's descendants "like the dust" evokes the creation of the human in Genesis 2.
- God's invitation for Avram to "walk about" the land carries on the theme of the righteous one walking in intimacy with God.
- God provides the land as an ark-like refuge of safety for Avram in the Eden hills while Lot chooses a false Eden down below, which will lead to ruin.

Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 13:12-18

¹² Avram dwelt in the land of Canaan,
and as for Lot, he dwelt in the cities of the valley ,
and he set up his tent by Sodom .
(¹³ Now, to Yahweh the men of Sodom were bad and moral-failures, very much .)

¹⁴ And Yahweh said to Avram,
after Lot separated from him,
a "Please lift up your eyes and see from the place where you are,
b to the north and to the south/Negev and to the east and to the west ,
a' ¹⁵ because all the land that you see ,
c to you I will give it , and to your seed , forever.
a ¹⁶ And I will make your seed like the dust of the land ,
b which, if one was able to count the dust of the land ,
a' then also your seed could be counted .
a ¹⁷ Arise , walk about in the land ,
b its length and its width ,
a' because to you I will give it ."

a ¹⁸ And Avram set up his tent ,
b and he went and dwelt by the oaks of Mamre ,
b' which are by Hebron ,
a' and he built there an altar to Yahweh.

Genesis 13:12-18. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Brothers Apart in Sodom and Hebron

Here Avram's sojourn into the land that began in [12:6](#) comes to completion when he finally settles in Hebron. The design of this unit highlights the contrast between the locations where Avram and Lot finally settle.

[Genesis 13:12-13](#) contrasts Avram's settlement in Canaan with Lot's settlement outside in the eastern valley of the Dead Sea, by Sodom. We recall from [13:10](#) that this valley is like Eden in Lot's eyes, but it turns out that this garden is full of bad seed. The two words used to describe Sodom echo the key words of the twin failures of the Eden story.

Genesis 13:13 Instructor's Translation

Now, to Yahweh the men of Sodom were **bad** (רע) and **moral-failures** (חטאים), very much.

- Adam and Eve fail at the tree of knowing good and **bad** (רע) because of the snake's deception (Gen. 3:6-7).
- Cain gives into the influence of "sin," that is, **moral failure** (חטאת) and murders his brother (Gen. 4:7).

In contrast, Avram dwells in a new Eden land, and the story concludes with him setting up his tent by the oak tree of Mamre near Hebron. Each element of this location's description ties into the larger symbolism of Eden, a place of tents, trees, divine visions.

Genesis 12:6-9

- Avram journeys through the land and camps near the oak of Moreh (אלון מורה) = "tree of seeing"

Genesis 12:10-13:11

- **12:10-20**
- **13:1-4**
- **13:5-11**

Genesis 13:18

- Avram settles in the land in his tent under the oaks of Mamre (אלני ממרא).

Genesis 12:6-13:18. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

A Promise Repeated and Expanded

God repeats his promises to Avram from 12:6 but expands both elements of seed and land.

Genesis 13:14-17 Instructor's Translation

¹⁴ And Yahweh said to Avram,
 after Lot separated from him,
 “Please lift up your eyes and see from the place where you are,
 to the north and to the south/Negev and to the east and to the west,
¹⁵ because all the land that you see,
 to you I will give it, and to your seed, forever.
¹⁶ And I will make your seed like the dust of the land,
 which, if one was able to count the dust of the land,
 then also your seed could be counted.
¹⁷ Arise, walk about in the land,
 its length and its width,
 because to you I will give it.”

These promise expansions echo back to the divine blessings upon Adam and Noah, showing that Avram is the recipient of the Eden promise for all nations.

Seed of the New Humanity

Like humanity in Eden, God will create a seed for Avram that is “like” the innumerable dust of the land.

Genesis 13:16 Instructor’s Translation

And I will make your **seed** like the **dust of the land**, which, if one was able to count the dust of the land, then also your seed could be counted.

Genesis 2:7-8 Instructor’s Translation

⁷ then Yahweh *Elohim* formed the human from the **dust from the ground** ... ⁸ and Yahweh *Elohim* planted a garden in Eden, toward the east, and he placed there the human whom he had formed.

The Land as an Ark of Safety, Avram as a New Noah

God’s speech echoes the language of Noah right before the onset of the flood. He walks with God, so he is summoned to create a floating Eden so that he and the animals can live together in a place of refuge as the violence of humans is met by the powerful waters. The ark, like the land, has a length and width, which will provide safety for any inside.

Genesis 13:17 Instructor’s Translation

Arise, **walk about** (התהלך) in the land, **its length and its width** (לארכה ולרחבה) because to you I will give it.

Genesis 6:8-9 Instructor’s Translation

⁸ But Noah found favor in the eyes of Yahweh. ⁹ These are the birth-generations of Noah; Noah was a righteous one, blameless in his generation; Noah **walked about** (התהלך) with *Elohim*;

Genesis 6:13-15 Instructor’s Translation

¹³ And *Elohim* said to Noah,
 “The end of all flesh has come before me, because the land is filled with violence because of them, and behold, I am going to cause ruin with the land.

¹⁴ Make for yourself an ark of gopher trees;
 you will make the ark with nests,
 and shall pitch it inside and out with pitch.

¹⁵ This is how you will make it:

- 300 cubits: **the length** (אֶרֶךְ) of the ark
- 50 cubits: **its width** (רָחֵבָה)
- 30 cubits: its height.”

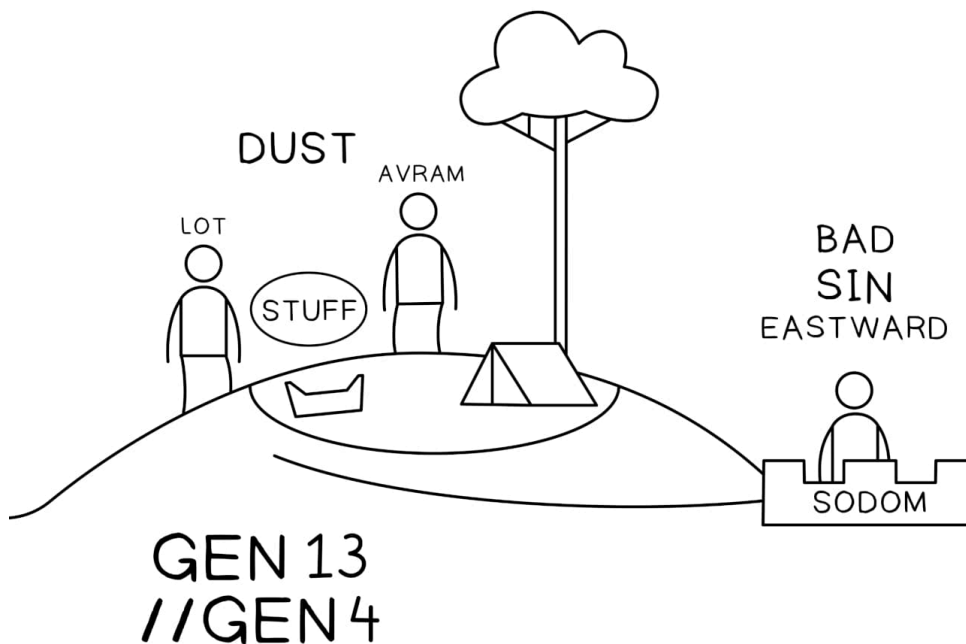
Genesis 12-13 as Replay of Genesis 2-6

Genesis 2 • God’s blessing of fruitful seed • Garden abundance • Sacred space of God’s presence by the tree of life on Mt. Eden	Genesis 3 • Foolish failure at the tree of testing that is “good of sight” • Deception and lack of trust in God’s word • Exile from Eden	Genesis 4-6 • Brothers with abundance • Jealousy and conflict • Brothers “separate” through violence • Non-chosen brother settles in the east, where violence is simmering, leading to a flood of judgment	Violence and Flood!
Genesis 12:1-9 • God's blessing of abundance and protection • Promise of fruitful seed • God's presence at tree and mountains	Genesis 12:10-20 • Foolish failure with Sarai who is "beautiful of sight" • Deception and lack of trust in God's word • Exile from false-Eden (i.e., Egypt)	Genesis 13 • Brother with abundance • Jealousy and conflict • Brothers separate through non-violence! • Non-chosen brother settles in the east, where violence is simmering, leading up to a flood of judgment	Violence and Flood!
Genesis 12-13 as Replay of Genesis 2-6. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).			

In both sequences, God appoints a chosen figure to receive divine blessing and to become a conduit of that blessing to others. Both figures fail in acts of folly that are rooted in a lack of trust in God’s wisdom and word.

Exile results in both cases, though the pattern is more sophisticated with Avram: He first undergoes a self-imposed exile from Canaan and then is exiled from Egypt by Pharaoh. It's only in Genesis 13 that Avram breaks that pattern. Once the conflict with Lot begins, Avram becomes a mediator for peace and avoids a violent conflict between brothers. Lot ends up choosing a place that is similar to Cain's city, a realm of violence (Lemek in Gen. 4:18-24; the violent warriors of Gen. 6:4; the wicked and violent men of Sodom in Gen. 13:13 and 14:1-10).

Avram's Hilltop Refuge



Avram's Hilltop Refuge. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

Reflection Question

What themes and key words in Genesis 13:14-20 recall the mountaintop garden of Eden? How have these themes been developed in Genesis 1-11?